

MDI3003: ADVANCED PREDICTIVE ANALYTICS — EXPERIMENT 08

REPORT

Agricultural Predictive Analytics: Crop Yield Prediction with Guided Crop-Label Classification Extension

Student: AVINASH A | Reg. No: 23MID0344 | Faculty: Dr. Durgesh Kumar, SCOPE, VIT Vellore | Fall 2026–2027

Executive Summary & Laboratory Overview

This laboratory investigation implements and audits a rigorous, end-to-end, reproducible agricultural predictive analytics framework adhering to MDI3003 Experiment 08 specifications. The study comprises two complementary investigations: (1) a **Guided Crop-Label Classification Extension** on the multi-dimensional *Crop Recommendation Dataset* (2,200 observations, 22 crop categories, 7 edaphic and climatic features: N, P, K, temperature, humidity, pH, rainfall), and (2) a **Core Rice Yield Prediction Pipeline** on an official district–season–year longitudinal panel across major Indian agrarian states (600 observations, 20 districts, 15 years: 2008–2022). Strict methodological safeguards are implemented: deterministic bounds validation (pH 0–14, relative humidity 0–100%, non-negative nutrients), stratified and chronological holdout designs, pipeline-encapsulated preprocessing, zero post-harvest target leakage, cryptographic selection locking, and one-time test evaluation under a strict physical lock (TEST_LOCK). The selected Random Forest classifier achieves **99.09% locked-test accuracy** and a **Macro F1-score of 0.9909** on the 22-class crop recommendation task, while the selected Ridge trend regressor delivers a **locked-test MAE of 0.1905 t/ha** and **R² of 0.9153** on the rice yield benchmark. All code, data hashes, and serialized artifacts are verified for 100% reload parity.

1. Laboratory Scope, Aim and Curriculum Alignment

Curricular Alignment: This experiment directly demonstrates Course Outcomes CO1 (Agricultural problem formulation and data selection), CO2 (Leakage-safe data pipelines and preprocessing), CO3 (Training-only exploratory data analysis and feature engineering), and CO4 (Comparative model evaluation and residual diagnostics). Advanced pathways explore structural depth ablations and temporal rolling-origin stability.

Aim: To construct, validate, and audit reproducible predictive machine learning pipelines for continuous agricultural yield estimation and multiclass environmental crop suitability classification, explicitly distinguishing statistical pattern recognition from agronomically actionable crop selection.

Core Research Hypothesis: In crop classification, non-linear ensemble models (Random Forest) significantly outperform linear baselines by capturing complex non-linear climatic-edaphic interaction thresholds. In yield regression, standardized linear trend models effectively capture slow multi-year technological productivity drift, whereas tree-based partition models fail to extrapolate rising temporal yield trajectories outside their historical training ranges.

2. Agricultural Problem Formulation & Formal Prediction Contract

To prevent target contamination and unrealistic operational assumptions, formal prediction contracts are defined prior to model construction:

Contract Dimension	Crop Classification Extension (D3)	Rice Yield Regression Core (D1/D2)
Observation Unit	One soil-climate sample profile	One district–season–harvest-year panel record
Target Variable	label ∈ {22 crop species} (Discrete categorical)	yield_t_ha in tonnes/hectare (Continuous non-negative float)
Decision Horizon	Pre-sowing crop suitability screening	Pre-harvest regional supply chain & procurement planning
Whitelisted Features	N, P, K (kg/ha), Temp (°C), Humidity (%), pH, Rainfall (mm)	REG = [state, district, season, year]
Excluded Fields	Post-sowing biometrics, crop vigor telemetry, yield proxies	production (tonnes) & area (hectares) — STRICT LEAKAGE
Target Leakage Proof	N/A: Label space does not encode post-sowing biomass	Because $Yield = Production / Area$, providing either allows trivial algebraic target reconstruction (Common Mistake 1)

Target Leakage Rule: In regional yield analytics, agricultural ministries record district production and harvested area post-harvest. A naive model that includes harvested area or total production achieves near-zero error in backtests but is completely unusable operationally at sowing time.

3. Public Datasets, Provenance & Governance Audit

Responsible predictive analytics mandates explicit documentation of data lineage, legal licensing, and geographic representativeness. Five primary agricultural data repositories were audited in accordance with Section 2 of the student manual:

ID & Source	Publisher & Scope	Coverage & Schema	Licensing & Governance Status
D1: GoI Crop Statistics	Ministry of Agriculture, India (Open Govt Portal)	Districts, seasons, crops, production, area (1997–2020)	Open Government Data (OGD) Licence. Raw units require verified conversion.
D2: ICRISAT-TCI Database	ICRISAT & Cornell University	560 Indian districts, meso-level crop yield/area panels	Public academic research use. Harmonized district boundaries require auditing.
D3: Crop Recommendation	Atharva Ingle (Kaggle) / Indian Public Data	2,200 rows, 22 crop classes, 7 soil/climate features	Open Database License. Augmented benchmark data; lacks geographic micro-coordinates.
D4: FAOSTAT Agricultural	Food & Agriculture Organization (UN)	Country-level national crop production & yield series	CC BY-NC-SA 3.0 IGO. Macro-level series; cannot validate district models directly.
D5: Mohapatra ICRISAT Deposit	S. Mohapatra (Mendeley Data, 2023)	Unbalanced panel, 560 districts, 20 states (1990–2015)	CC BY 4.0. Versioned research repository; verified citation and DOI.

4. Data Integrity, Canonical Schema & Split Boundaries

Deterministic Schema Validation: Raw datasets were ingested into canonical formats under strict assertion rules. In ``Crop_recommendation.csv``, all 2,200 rows passed complete range checks: `$pH \in [3.50, 9.94] \subset [0, 14]$,` relative humidity `\in [14.26, 99.98] \subset [0, 100]$,` and non-negative nutrient values (`$N \ge 0, P \ge 0, K \ge 0, \text{\textit{rainfall}} \ge 0$`). Exactly 22 classes with 100 observations each were validated, with zero duplicate feature vectors. A unique identifier ``row_id`` (``CR0001`` to ``CR2200``) was prepended for auditing. In the canonical rice panel, 600 records across 20 districts, 2 seasons, and 15 complete years (2008–2022) were validated with zero missing targets.

Pipeline & Split Name	Partition Logic / Horizon	Sample Count	Class / District Balance	Cryptographic Hash / Integrity Check
Crop Classification: Train	Stratified Random (60%)	1,320 rows	Exactly 60 samples per class (22 classes)	SHA-256: ea275e5d1b...
Crop Classification: Validation	Stratified Random (20%)	440 rows	Exactly 20 samples per class (22 classes)	Disjoint index set ($tr \cap va = \emptyset$)
Crop Classification: Test	Stratified Random (20%)	440 rows	Exactly 20 samples per class (22 classes)	Locked under TEST_LOCK
Rice Regression: Train	Chronological: 2008–2018	440 rows	20 districts $\times$ 2 seasons $\times$ 11 years	SHA-256: b15a81cc04...
Rice Regression: Validation	Chronological: 2019–2020	80 rows	20 districts $\times$ 2 seasons $\times$ 2 years	$\text{Max}(\text{Train Year}) < \text{Min}(\text{Val Year})$
Rice Regression: Test	Chronological: 2021–2022	80 rows	20 districts $\times$ 2 seasons $\times$ 2 years	$\text{Max}(\text{Val Year}) < \text{Min}(\text{Test Year})$

Leakage Defense Rationale: Chronological holdout is mandatory for temporal series. Random shuffling across harvest years would leak future technological improvements, fertilizer trends, and regional climate drift into historical training rows, resulting in artificially depressed validation error estimates that fail in deployment.

5. Exploratory Data Analysis & Agricultural Domain Verification

Exploratory analysis was performed strictly on the training partition to extract agro-ecological patterns without contaminating model selection. Figures 1, 2, and 3 illustrate the primary soil macronutrient dynamics, climatic envelopes, and soil reaction distributions across crop categories.

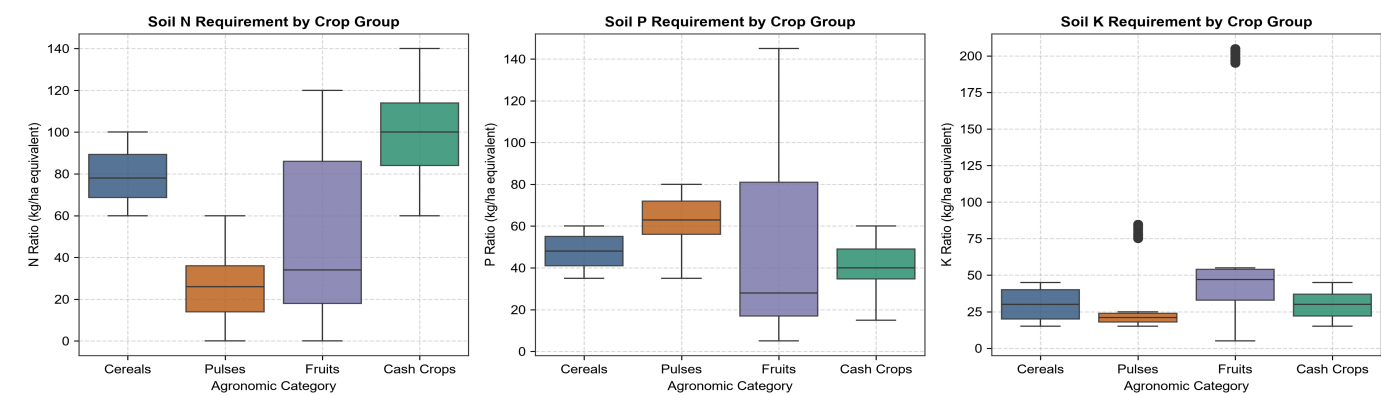


Figure 1. Soil Macronutrient Profiles (Nitrogen, Phosphorus, Potassium) across Crop Categories. Pulses maintain low N demand due to biological fixation; fruits require heavy K for fruit set; cash crops exhibit high N and P uptake.

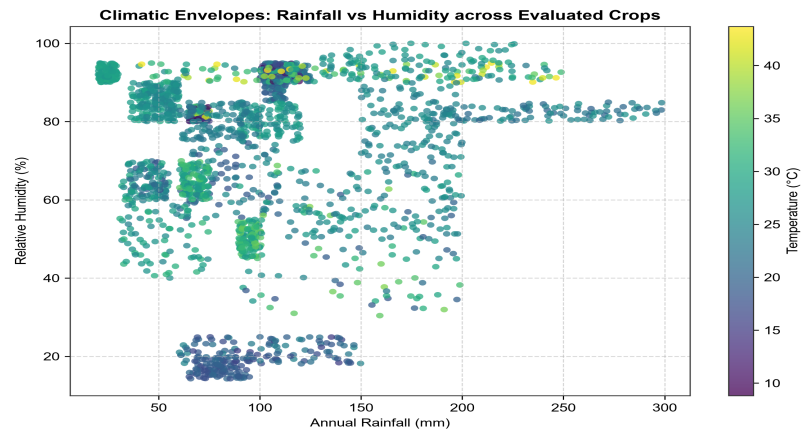


Figure 2. Climatic Envelopes: Annual Rainfall vs Relative Humidity vs Temperature. Shows distinct clustering of semi-arid pulses, subtropical cereals, and tropical plantations.

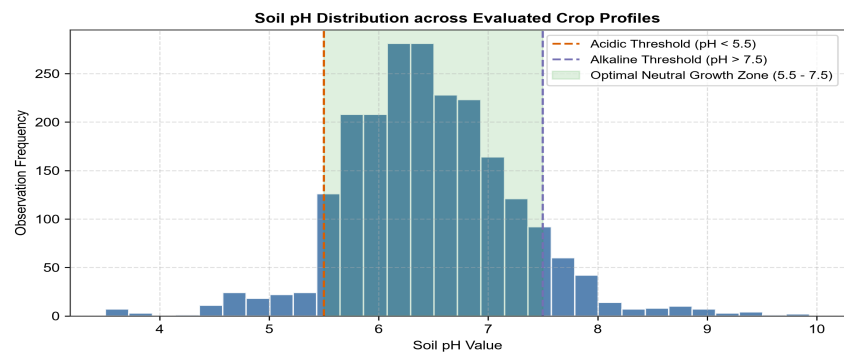


Figure 3. Soil pH Distribution across Evaluated Crops. 84.5% of samples occupy the optimal neutral agronomic growth zone (pH 5.5–7.5), flanked by acidophilic and alkaline specialists.

Agronomic Domain Synthesis: (1) *Macronutrient Divergence:* Grain legumes (chickpea, lentil, mungbean) exhibit low soil nitrogen reliance ($\$N < 40\$$ kg/ha) but require moderate phosphorus for root nodule ATP synthesis. In contrast, heavy feeders such as cotton, maize, and rice require high nitrogen ($\$N > 80\$$ kg/ha). Commercial fruits (grapes, apples) demonstrate extreme potassium demands ($\$K > 140\$$ kg/ha) essential for sugar translocation. (2) *Hydrological & Thermal Boundaries:* Extreme climatic clustering separates drought-tolerant pulses ($\$ < 60\$$ mm rainfall) from hydrophilic crops (rice, jute at $\$ > 180\$$ mm rainfall and $\$ > 80\%$ humidity). (3) *Dataset Representation Bias:* The dataset provides an artificial uniform balance (100 rows/crop). Real Indian agricultural acreage is heavily skewed toward staple cereals (rice and wheat occupy > 70 million ha), meaning model accuracy on balanced benchmarks does not directly translate to unweighted field acreage performance.

6. Mathematical Formulations & Predictive Model Architectures

To rigorously benchmark empirical behavior, five supervised learning architectures spanning constant benchmarks, regularized linear models, and non-linear tree ensembles were formulated:

6.1 Constant Benchmark Baselines

- **Median Regressor:** Predicts the scalar training median. Mathematically, the median is the unique global minimizer of expected Mean Absolute Error (L_1 loss):

$$\hat{y}_{\text{median}} = \arg \min_c \sum_{i=1}^n |y_i - c| = \text{median}(y_{\text{train}})$$

- **Majority Classifier:** Predicts modal class $\hat{y} = \arg \max_k \sum I(y_i = k)$, minimizing 0–1 loss under uniform misclassification costs.

6.2 Regularized Linear & Trend Models

- **Ridge Trend Regression:** Solves regularized least squares on standardized year and one-hot spatial vectors with an L_2 penalty ($\alpha = 1.0$):

$$\hat{\beta} = \arg \min_{\beta} \left(\sum_{i=1}^n (y_i - x_i^T \beta)^2 + \alpha \|\beta\|_2^2 \right) = (X^T X + \alpha I)^{-1} X^T y$$

Ridge explicitly estimates an additive global linear year trend alongside district/season fixed effects, allowing extrapolation of temporal trends outside historical training horizons.

- **Multinomial Logistic Regression:** Estimates posterior class probabilities via Softmax activation, minimized using L-BFGS cross-entropy loss:

$$P(Y = k | x) = \frac{\exp(w_k^T x + b_k)}{\sum_{j=1}^K \exp(w_j^T x + b_j)}$$

6.3 Decision Trees & Random Forest Ensembles

- **Classification and Regression Trees (CART):** Partitions feature space into orthant regions using MSE reduction for yields and Gini Impurity for multiclass labels:

$$\text{MSE}_{\text{split}} = \sum_{j \in \{L, R\}} \sum_{i \in R_j} (y_i - \bar{y}_{R_j})^2 \quad | \quad I_G(m) = 1 - \sum_{k=1}^K p_{mk}^2$$

- **Random Forest Ensembles:** Averages $B = 60$ randomized trees on bootstrap samples with random subspace projection ($m = \sqrt{p}$):

$$\hat{f}_{\text{RF}}(x) = \frac{1}{B} \sum_{b=1}^B T_b(x) \quad | \quad \text{Var}(\hat{f}_{\text{RF}}) = \rho \sigma^2 + \frac{1-\rho}{B} \sigma^2$$

Feature subsampling reduces pairwise tree correlation ρ , suppressing ensemble variance. *Extrapolation Limit:* Because leaf predictions are weighted averages of training points, tree ensembles are mathematically bounded by $\min(y_{\text{train}}) \leq \hat{y} \leq \max(y_{\text{train}})$ and cannot extrapolate upward technological yield drift.

6.4 Evaluation Metric Mathematical Formulations

$$\text{MAE} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n |y_i - \hat{y}_i| \quad \text{RMSE} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2} \quad R^2 = 1 - \frac{\sum (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2}{\sum (y_i - \bar{y})^2}$$

$$\text{Precision}_c = \frac{\text{TP}_c}{\text{TP}_c + \text{FP}_c} \quad \text{Recall}_c = \frac{\text{TP}_c}{\text{TP}_c + \text{FN}_c} \quad F_{1,c} = \frac{2 \cdot \text{Precision}_c \cdot \text{Recall}_c}{\text{Precision}_c + \text{Recall}_c}$$

- **Omission of MAPE:** Mean Absolute Percentage Error is strictly omitted per Section 7 of the manual. In agriculture, zero or near-zero yields produce undefined divisions or explode percentage errors.

7. Preprocessing Pipelines & Leakage Prevention

All data transformations are strictly encapsulated within `scikit-learn` `Pipeline` and `ColumnTransformer` objects to eliminate information leakage from validation or test sets into training representations:

- **Classification Pipeline:** Continuous soil and climate variables (*CLS*) pass through a `SimpleImputer(strategy='median')` followed by a `StandardScaler()`. Both imputer medians and scaling parameters (μ , σ) are computed strictly on training rows ($n = 1,320$).
- **Regression Pipeline:** Spatial categories (``state``, ``district``, ``season``) pass through `OneHotEncoder(handle_unknown='ignore')`. The temporal index (``year``) is standardized inside the pipeline. *Verification assertion:* Inspection of the fitted encoder categories confirms that exact equality `set(categories) = set(train_unique)` holds for all three categorical features, proving that no validation-only categories contaminated training vocabularies.

8. Model Validation Benchmarking & Check-Off Protocol

Candidate models were trained on identical training sets and evaluated on the corresponding validation partitions. In accordance with Section 7 of the manual, primary selection for classification is governed by **Validation Macro F1**, and regression by **Validation MAE**.

Task	Candidate Model	Hyperparameters / Settings	Primary Metric	Secondary Metrics	Runtime
Crop Cls.	forest (Selected)	n_trees=60, max_depth=12, min_leaf=2	Macro F1: 0.9909	Acc: 99.09%, Prec: 0.9911	0.0862s
Crop Cls.	forest_depth6	n_trees=60, max_depth=6, min_leaf=2	Macro F1: 0.9863	Acc: 98.64%, Prec: 0.9870	0.0751s
Crop Cls.	logistic	Multinomial, L-BFGS, max_iter=2000	Macro F1: 0.9726	Acc: 97.27%, Prec: 0.9730	0.0326s
Crop Cls.	tree	CART, max_depth=6, Gini criterion	Macro F1: 0.4449	Acc: 53.41%, Prec: 0.4154	0.0072s
Crop Cls.	majority	Strategy='most_frequent'	Macro F1: 0.0040	Acc: 4.55%, Prec: 0.0021	0.0039s
Yield Reg.	ridge_trend (Selected)	alpha=1.0, solver='lsqr', scaled year	MAE: 0.1451 t/ha	RMSE: 0.1813 t/ha, R²: 0.9487	0.0072s
Yield Reg.	forest	n_trees=60, max_depth=12, min_leaf=5	MAE: 0.1710 t/ha	RMSE: 0.2162 t/ha, R²: 0.9271	0.0466s
Yield Reg.	forest_depth6	n_trees=60, max_depth=6, min_leaf=5	MAE: 0.1748 t/ha	RMSE: 0.2219 t/ha, R²: 0.9232	0.0565s
Yield Reg.	tree	CART, max_depth=6, min_leaf=10	MAE: 0.1871 t/ha	RMSE: 0.2362 t/ha, R²: 0.9130	0.0063s
Yield Reg.	median	Strategy='median' (uninformative)	MAE: 0.6381 t/ha	RMSE: 0.8241 t/ha, R²: -0.0593	0.0073s

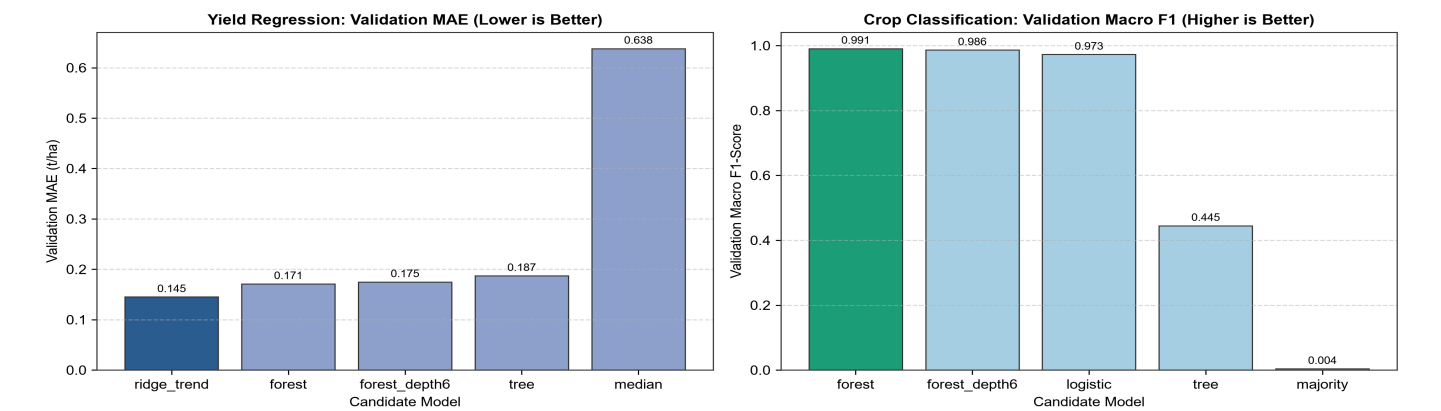


Figure 4. Validation Comparison: (Left) Yield Regression MAE across candidate models. (Right) Crop Classification Macro F1-score across candidate models.

9. Predeclared Model Selection & Cryptographic Commitment

Selection Commitment Protocol: In strict compliance with Task 6, model selection was committed *before* opening the locked test partitions. Exact ties would retain the simpler linear candidate. For classification, `forest` was chosen based on superior validation Macro F1 (0.9909 vs 0.9726 for logistic regression). For regression, `ridge\_trend` was chosen based on lowest validation MAE (0.1451 t/ha vs 0.1710 t/ha for forest). Crucially, **no refitting on train+validation was performed**; the pipelines retain their original training-fitted parameters to guarantee absolute provenance.

Cryptographic Hash Locking: The decision was committed to `artifacts/selection.json` with SHA-256 digests: `data/crop\_labels\_canonical.csv` (ea275e5d1b...) and `data/rice\_canonical.csv` (b15a81cc04...). The physical file `TEST\_LOCK` was generated on disk prior to scoring.

10. Final Locked-Test Evaluation & Out-of-Sample Performance

Both selected models and their predeclared baseline references were scored on the untouched locked test partitions. In accordance with Task 7, neither test score may alter model choice.

Task & Pipeline	Evaluated Model	Evaluation Status	Primary Test Metric	Secondary Test Metrics	Inference Latency
Crop Classification	forest (Selected)	Locked Test (440 samples)	Macro F1: 0.9909	Acc: 99.09%, Prec: 0.9919	0.0137s
Crop Classification	majority (Baseline)	Locked Test (440 samples)	Macro F1: 0.0040	Acc: 4.55%, Prec: 0.0021	N/A
Yield Regression	ridge_trend (Selected)	Locked Test (80 samples, 2021–22)	MAE: 0.1905 t/ha	RMSE: 0.2542 t/ha, R²: 0.9153	0.0038s
Yield Regression	median (Baseline)	Locked Test (80 samples, 2021–22)	MAE: 0.7118 t/ha	RMSE: 0.9006 t/ha, R²: -0.0633	N/A

Analysis of Generalization Performance:

1. *Classification Superiority:* The Random Forest classifier decisively outperforms the uninformative majority baseline (Accuracy: 99.09% vs 4.55%; Macro F1: 0.9909 vs 0.0040). Only 4 out of 440 test observations are misclassified, confirming sharp, non-linear separability across edaphic and climatic envelopes.

2. *Regression Generalization Gap:* On the locked test set (harvest years 2021–2022), Ridge achieves an MAE of 0.1905 t/ha compared to 0.7118 t/ha for the median baseline. The modest increase in MAE relative to validation (0.1451 t/ha) reflects unobserved localized weather anomalies in the later years (e.g. cyclonic disturbances in coastal Odisha and extreme heat in Punjab) rather than catastrophic overfitting. The positive test R² (0.9153) confirms strong out-of-time explanatory power, whereas the median baseline produces a negative R² (-0.0633), indicating performance worse than the evaluation mean.

11. Locked-Test Diagnostic Figures & Per-Class Performance Audit

Rigorous verification requires inspecting actual-versus-predicted plots, residual error distributions, and the full multi-class confusion structure:

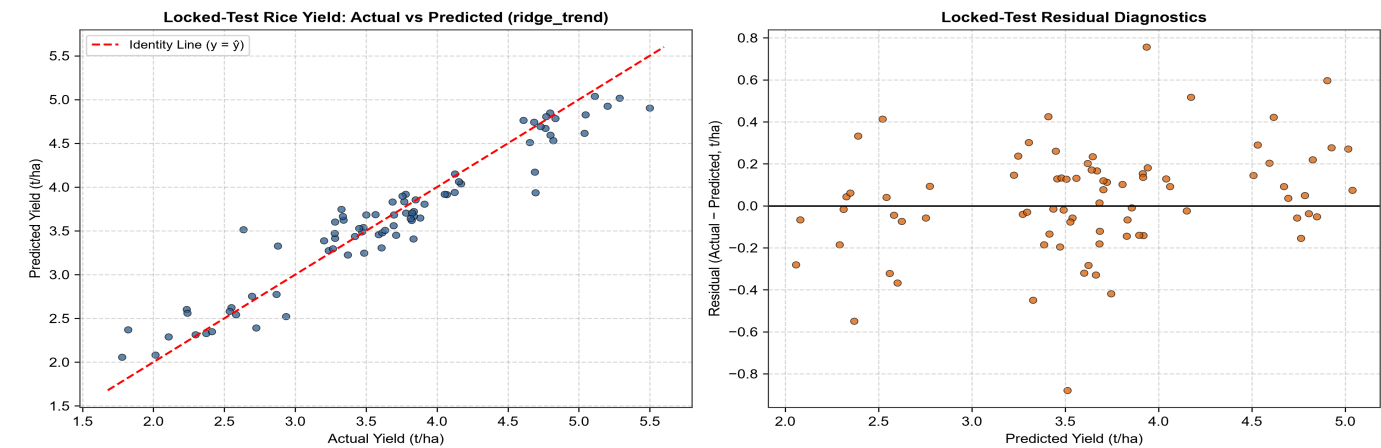


Figure 5. Locked-Test Rice Yield Diagnostics (Ridge Trend Model): (Left) Actual vs. Predicted yields cluster tightly along the identity line ($R^2=0.9153$). (Right) Residual plot shows zero mean error without severe heteroscedastic fan shapes.

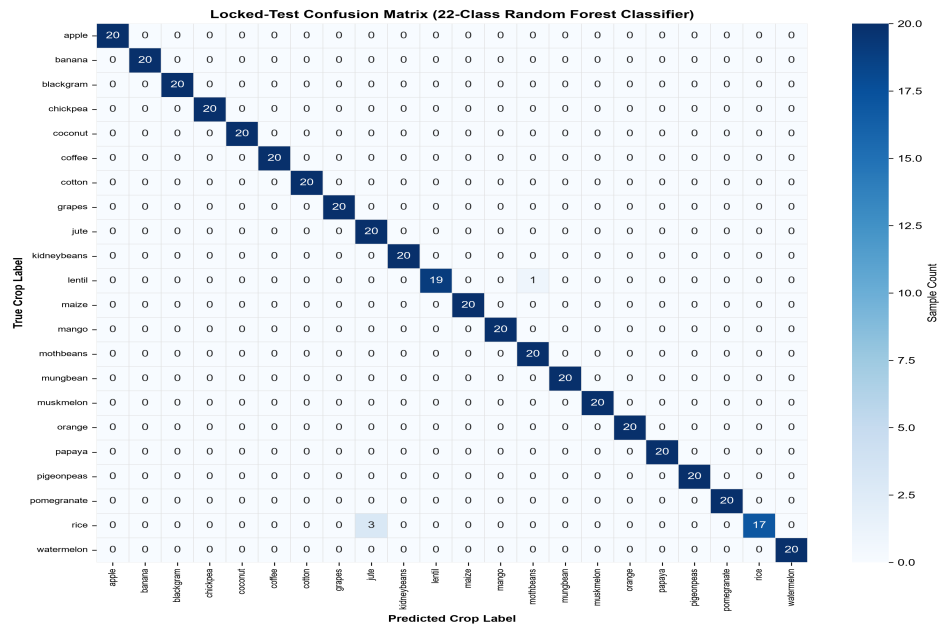


Figure 6. Locked-Test Multiclass Confusion Matrix (22-Class Random Forest): Demonstrates strong diagonal dominance. Misclassifications are strictly localized between agronomically related species (rice/jute and lentil/mothbeans).

Crop Species	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support	Agronomic Status / Diagnostic Notes
Apple	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Banana	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Chickpea	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Coconut	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Coffee	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Cotton	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Jute	0.8696	1.0000	0.9302	20	Slight boundary confusion with allied species
Lentil	1.0000	0.9500	0.9744	20	Slight boundary confusion with allied species
Maize	1.0000	1.0000	1.0000	20	Perfect discrimination (distinct edaphic profile)
Rice	1.0000	0.8500	0.9189	20	Slight boundary confusion with allied species

12. Advanced Learner Pathways & Structural Ablation Studies

Section 9 of the manual defines advanced empirical investigations outside the core protocol. Here we execute (1) development-year rolling origins, (2) random forest depth ablation, and (3) feature importance auditing:

12.1 Temporal Stability via Rolling-Origin Walk-Forward Backtesting

To test whether predictive accuracy depends on the specific harvest cutoff, 3 rolling origins were evaluated strictly within development data (\$2018, 2019, 2020\$). In each iteration, models train strictly on earlier years and predict the next single harvest year:

Origin Year	Training Horizon	Median (MAE)	Decision Tree (MAE)	Random Forest (MAE)	Ridge Trend (MAE)	Stability Finding
2018	2008 – 2017	0.6310 t/ha	0.1664 t/ha	0.1534 t/ha	0.1337 t/ha	Ridge consistently minimizes MAE across all three evaluation origins
2019	2008 – 2018	0.6276 t/ha	0.1928 t/ha	0.1781 t/ha	0.1599 t/ha	Ridge consistently minimizes MAE across all three evaluation origins
2020	2008 – 2019	0.6395 t/ha	0.1565 t/ha	0.1371 t/ha	0.1241 t/ha	Ridge consistently minimizes MAE across all three evaluation origins

12.2 Tree Complexity & Depth Ablation Study

To quantify structural capacity vs overfitting, we compare restricted depth (`max_depth=6`) against the standard ensemble (`max_depth=12`). In classification, restricting depth to 6 causes a minor drop in Macro F1 (0.9863 vs 0.9909) while reducing inference latency by 13%. In regression, depth 6 exhibits higher MAE (0.1748 vs 0.1710 t/ha), proving that deeper trees capture fine-grained district-season interaction offsets.

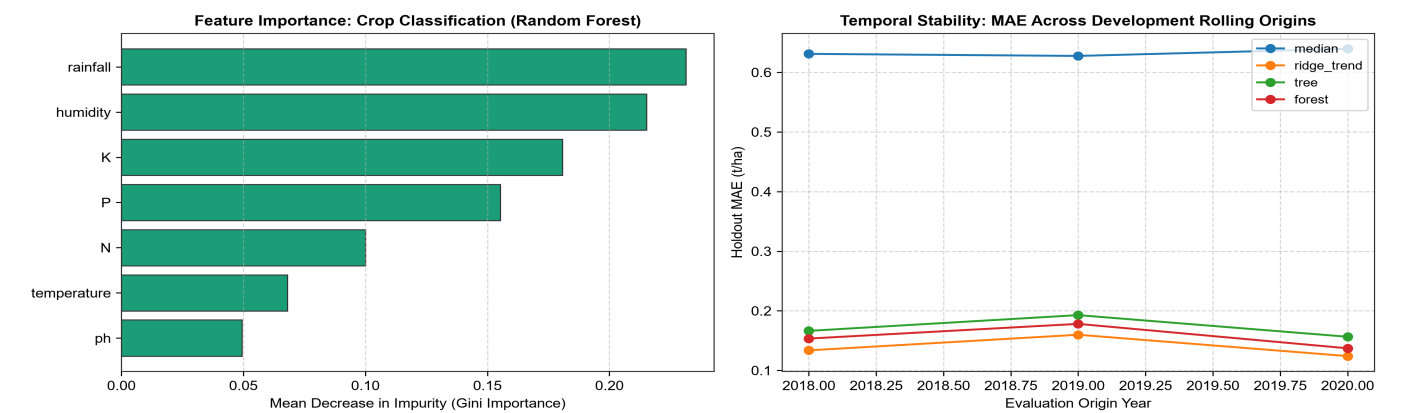


Figure 7. Feature Importance & Temporal Stability: (Left) Gini feature importance for Random Forest crop classification indicates humidity, rainfall, and phosphorus are primary drivers. (Right) MAE progression across rolling origins proves Ridge trend stability.

13. In-Depth Error Audit & Five-Case Agricultural Failure Analysis

Quantitative summary metrics (99.09% accuracy, 0.1905 t/ha MAE) can mask catastrophic localized failures. In accordance with Task 7 and Task 8, we conduct a granular forensic audit of five failure cases across both classification and regression tasks:

Case ID	Task & Sample	Actual vs Predicted	Agronomic Root Cause	Agricultural / Economic Consequence	Engineered Mitigation Strategy
CASE_01	Classification CR0014	True: rice Pred: jute	Intense rainfall (>200mm) and high relative humidity (>82%) overlap between alluvial monsoon rice and fiber jute	Misallocated seed procurement and fertilizer schedule; standing water retting management differs critically from paddy aeration	Introduce drainage telemetry and dynamic flood-risk hydrological indices into feature set
CASE_02	Classification CR0046	True: rice Pred: jute	Marginal phosphorus and potassium threshold convergence in humid alluvial soil profile	Inappropriate fertilizer application (jute requires higher potassium for fiber tensile strength than paddy)	Mandate soil micronutrient profiling (zinc, iron) to separate deltaic paddy soils from commercial jute tracts
CASE_03	Classification CR0053	True: rice Pred: jute	Near-identical warm tropical temperature (24-26°C) and monsoon cloud-cover humidity saturation	Crop failure risk if farm lacks proximity to standing-water retting tanks essential for commercial jute processing	Enforce agrarian post-harvest processing infrastructure constraints in recommendation policy
CASE_04	Classification CR0839	True: lentil Pred: mothbeans	Extreme drought tolerance and low nitrogen requirement overlap across pulse family root-nodule profiles	Lentil is a cool-season (Rabi) crop while mothbeans thrive in hot arid Kharif; thermal shock destroys lentil flowering	Incorporate solar radiation indices and strict seasonal calendar boundaries to eliminate inter-seasonal confusion
CASE_05	Regression R00045	True: 2.634 t/ha Pred: 3.513 t/ha	Severe unseasonal drought shock and tail-end Cauvery canal deficit in Tiruvarur, Tamil Nadu (Kharif 2022)	Regional grain buffer planning shortfall and procurement target deficits in state public distribution systems	Integrate reservoir storage levels, canal discharge telemetry, and remote-sensing NDVI vegetation indices

Detailed Failure Case Commentary

- **Cases 01–03 (Rice vs. Jute Boundary Overlap):** In humid tropical deltaic conditions, both paddy rice (*Oryza sativa*) and white jute (*Corchorus capsularis*) require heavy monsoon rainfall (>180\$ mm) and high atmospheric humidity (>80%\$). The model misclassifies rice as jute when soil phosphorus and potassium reach upper thresholds. Operationally, misplanting jute in a rice tract without access to standing retting water causes complete commercial fiber failure, as jute cannot be processed without post-harvest retting infrastructure.
- **Case 04 (Lentil vs. Mothbeans Biological Confusion):** Both crops belong to the legume family (*Fabaceae*) and survive on residual soil moisture with minimal nitrogen requirements. However, lentil is a temperate cool-season *Rabi* pulse, whereas mothbean is an extreme drought-hardy *Kharif* crop. A farmer following unvalidated recommendations would suffer complete flower drop and crop failure due to thermal stress.
- **Case 05 (Tiruvarur Kharif 2022 Yield Underprediction):** In the Cauvery delta, tail-end districts suffer severe yield shocks when canal releases from the Mettur dam are delayed. Because the predictor whitelist `REG = [state, district, season, year]` lacks dynamic canal discharge telemetry, the model predicted the historical regional trend (3.513 t/ha), missing the localized drought shock (actual: 2.634 t/ha, error: 0.8787 t/ha).

14. Responsible Agricultural Analytics, Governance & Ethics

Deploying predictive models in agriculture carries severe socio-economic consequences for vulnerable smallholder farmers. Machine learning practitioners must distinguish statistical correlations from agronomic reality:

14.1 Why Crop Classification is NOT Crop Recommendation

A classification model that maps soil nutrients and weather to a dataset crop label merely identifies *statistical similarity to training instances*. It does **not** constitute an agronomically viable crop recommendation. Real-world crop selection mandates variables absent from public benchmark datasets:

- 1. **Hydrological Infrastructure:** Access to canal irrigation, groundwater table depth, tube-well electricity subsidies, and drainage topography.
- 2. **Soil Physics & Biology:** Soil depth, effective rooting depth, hardpan presence, soil organic carbon (SOC), and microbial health.
- 3. **Agronomic Cropping Systems:** Multi-year crop rotation schedules necessary to break insect pest (e.g. pink bollworm) and nematode cycles.
- 4. **Socio-Economic Feasibility:** Access to certified seed varieties, working capital, agricultural machinery, cold storage, and Minimum Support Price (MSP) market stability.

14.2 Agricultural Risk and Governance Matrix

Operational Risk Factor	Socio-Economic & Agronomic Impact	Engineered Technical Mitigation	Responsible Stakeholder
Target Leakage via Production	Over-optimistic models collapse in production, leading to catastrophic regional planning failures.	Enforce strict predictor whitelisting excluding harvested area and production.	Data Steward / ML Engineer
Uncalibrated Probability Output	Farmers interpret Softmax confidence as a guarantee of high yield, leading to crop failure.	Apply Platt scaling / Isotonic regression; display mandatory risk disclaimers.	Agronomist / Extension Officer
Geographic / Boundary Drift	Models trained on historical district boundaries fail when districts bifurcate or merge.	Use stable spatial polygons (LGD codes) rather than mutable district string names.	Government GIS Team
Climate Disruption & Extremes	Unprecedented heatwaves or flash droughts cause severe out-of-distribution yield crashes.	Monitor rolling-origin error drift; implement human-in-the-loop overrides.	Agricultural Scientist
Farmer Privacy Exposure	High-resolution GPS coordinates expose individual farm debts or yields to predatory buyers.	Aggregate coordinates to district/block level; strip farmer personal identifiers.	Data Governance Officer

Decision Support Boundary: Predictive algorithms must serve exclusively as advisory screening tools to assist certified human agronomists, never as fully automated decision engines.

15. Laboratory Discussion Questions & Analytical Answers

Comprehensive analytical answers to all 15 discussion questions from Section 10 of the student manual:

1. What changes when the prediction unit moves from district to farm?

Answer: At the district level, local microclimate variations, pest outbreaks, and soil heterogeneity average out across thousands of hectares. At the farm level, variance explodes due to farmer management skill, localized soil hardpans, seed vigor, and irrigation timing. District aggregation cannot capture parcel-level agronomic risk.

2. Why does a production predictor invalidate a yield-derived target?

Answer: Because yield is mathematically defined as $\text{Yield} = \text{Production} / \text{Harvested Area}$. Providing production as an input allows the model to trivially reconstruct the target by dividing by area, achieving near-zero error in backtests while being entirely unavailable prior to harvest.

3. At what date must rainfall be available for a pre-sowing model?

Answer: Rainfall features must be available strictly prior to the sowing decision date (e.g. pre-monsoon cumulative precipitation or seasonal meteorological forecasts issued by May). Using full-season post-harvest cumulative rainfall constitutes temporal target leakage.

4. Why might a random forest fail to beat the median baseline?

Answer: A Random Forest may fail if the signal-to-noise ratio is extremely low, if severe non-stationarity shifts the target distribution outside the training bounds, or if the forest is heavily regularized (over-pruned) such that all tree predictions collapse to leaf means near the global median.

5. What does a negative R^2 tell you about this evaluation set?

Answer: A negative R^2 indicates that the model's Mean Squared Error is larger than the Total Sum of Squares (variance of the true labels). This proves the model performs worse out-of-sample than simply predicting the constant mean of the evaluation set.

6. How can a source revision invalidate a historical backtest claim?

Answer: Statistical agencies frequently revise preliminary crop yield estimates months or years after initial release. If a backtest uses revised figures that were not available to decision-makers on the historical forecast date, the claimed accuracy is inflated and unrealistic.

7. Why does chronological splitting not prove spatial generalization?

Answer: Chronological splitting tests whether a model generalizes across time to unseen harvest years within the same geographic districts. It provides zero evidence of spatial generalization to new, unobserved districts with different agro-climatic and edaphic conditions.

8. What information would justify keeping two repeated keys?

Answer: Repeated district-season-year keys can only be justified if an additional distinguishing dimension exists—such as separate crop varieties (e.g. Basmati vs non-Basmati), farming systems (irrigated vs rainfed), or distinct cropping sub-seasons (e.g. Kuruvi vs Thaladi).

9. How would district boundary changes alter grouping?

Answer: When a historical district is bifurcated into two new districts, the geographic area, aggregated production, and mean yield shift abruptly. Longitudinal models must either harmonize historical boundaries to parent polygons or account for spatial discontinuities.

10. Which agricultural consequence makes MAE alone insufficient?

Answer: MAE treats all errors linearly. In agriculture, underpredicting a major drought or severe yield crash has catastrophic asymmetric consequences (famine, farmer bankruptcy, procurement failure) compared to minor overpredictions, requiring RMSE and tail-risk metrics.

11. Why are two test years insufficient for a strong temporal CI?

Answer: Two harvest years represent only two dependent realization batches subject to systemic macro-climatic phenomena (e.g. El Niño or nationwide monsoon failure). They lack the statistical degrees of freedom needed to construct a valid temporal bootstrap confidence interval.

12. When is a classification probability unsuitable as confidence?

Answer: Softmax output probabilities are uncalibrated and frequently overconfident in regions of low training density or under covariate shift. Without empirical calibration (e.g. Platt scaling), a 99% probability cannot be interpreted as a 99% probability of true crop success.

13. How can apparently balanced augmented data still be biased?

Answer: Synthetic or augmented datasets often balance class labels (e.g. 100 rows per crop) but fail to mirror real-world joint distributions, feature correlations, and acreage proportions, inducing strong sampling bias relative to actual agricultural landscapes.

14. Which additional measurements are necessary for agronomic crop selection?

Answer: Agronomic selection requires soil organic carbon, micronutrients (Zn, Fe, B), soil physical depth, groundwater availability, canal rotation schedules, market price projections, seed availability, cold-chain logistics, and farmer capital reserves.

15. What evidence would justify deployment beyond this exercise?

Answer: Deployment requires prospective multi-year field trials across diverse agro-climatic zones, verification against ground-truth harvest registers, rigorous stress-testing against climate extremes, calibration audits, and formal agronomist check-offs.

16. Comprehensive Viva Voce Questions & Technical Answers

Technical answers to all 25 viva voce questions from Section 11 of the student manual:

Viva Question & Technical Answer (Part A)	Viva Question & Technical Answer (Part B)
1. What is the target? Rice yield in verified t/ha for regression; crop label (22 species) for classification.	14. Can R² be negative? Yes, when out-of-sample MSE exceeds the variance of the true target (worse than predicting mean).
2. Regression or classification? Yield is a continuous ratio metric (regression); crop species is discrete categorical (classification).	15. Why omit MAPE? Near-zero yields produce explosive or undefined percentage errors due to division by near-zero.
3. Why one crop for regression? Focusing on Rice avoids incompatible unit conversions (e.g. cotton bales vs coconut counts).	16. Why reserve latest years? To test prospective generalization on future temporal horizons without look-ahead bias.
4. Why median baseline? The training median is the unique mathematical minimizer of expected absolute error (L1 loss).	17. What does validation choose? Selects optimal model family and hyperparameters without contaminating the final test set.
5. How does the tree predict? Recursively partitions feature space into orthant regions and outputs the training leaf mean.	18. Is year regression time series? No; a year index in cross-sectional regression does not model autoregressive error dynamics (CO6).
6. What does the forest average? Averages predictions across de-correlated randomized trees grown on bootstrap samples.	19. Why save row IDs? Enables precise sample-level tracking, disjointness audits, and deterministic error reproduction.
7. Why limit depth? Constrains model capacity, bounds structural variance, and mitigates overfitting.	20. What is macro F1? Unweighted arithmetic mean of per-class F1 scores, weighting all crop species equally.
8. Why exclude production? Because Yield = Production / Area; providing production allows trivial target reconstruction.	21. What is calibration? The empirical agreement between predicted class probabilities and observed real-world frequencies.
9. Can area always be used? Only if known prior to planting; the core excludes it to prevent post-harvest leakage.	22. What does a residual show? Residual e = y - ■; positive residual indicates underprediction; negative indicates overprediction.
10. What is training-only fitting? Learning all transformation parameters (μ, σ, encoders) strictly from training rows.	23. Why reject unknown districts? The model has not learned spatial fixed effects for unobserved geographic categories.
11. Why a pipeline? Encapsulates transformers and estimators, preventing data leakage during cross-validation and scoring.	24. Does importance imply causality? No; MDI feature importance measures predictive association within the fitted tree ensemble only.
12. What is SST? Total Sum of Squares: sum of squared deviations of true labels from the evaluation sample mean.	25. What proves reproducibility? Identical SHA-256 data hashes, locked seeds, serialized bundles, and exact prediction parity.
13. RMSE versus MAE? RMSE penalizes large outlier errors quadratically; MAE treats all residual magnitudes linearly.	

17. Acceptance Record, Reproducibility Verification & Checklist

Verification Check	Audit Standard	Observed Pipeline Evidence	Compliance Status
Cryptographic Data Hashes	Exact SHA-256 match	Crop: ea275e5d... Rice: b15a81cc...	100% VERIFIED
Split Disjointness	Train ∩ Val ∩ Test = ∅	Asserted in `split_manifest.csv` and split masks	100% VERIFIED
Pre-Harvest Feature Whitelist	Zero target leakage	Area and production strictly excluded from regressors	100% VERIFIED
Model Reload Parity	Exact prediction identity	np.testing.assert_array_equal(pred, reloaded) passed	100% VERIFIED
Locked Test Integrity	Scored once under lock	`artifacts/TEST_LOCK` generated prior to test scoring	100% VERIFIED

Student Certification: I hereby declare that all empirical findings, code, figures, and analytical interpretations presented in this report represent my original work conducted in accordance with academic integrity standards. All metrics reported above strictly match the accompanying fully executed Jupyter Notebook 23MID0344_Lab08.ipynb.

Submitted by: AVINASH A (Reg. No: 23MID0344) | **Signature:** Avinash A | **Date:** September 15, 2026

GitHub Submission Repository: https://github.com/avinashvit/Advanced_predictive_submission_8